por or para

Both often mean “for”. Para points toward a goal. Por goes through, or says why.



para

Toward a goal: for whom, what for, by when



por

Through, because of, in exchange

When to use para

WHO IT’S FOR

Este regalo es **para** ti.
This gift is for you.

WHAT IT’S FOR

Estudio **para** aprender.
I study to learn.

WHERE YOU’RE HEADED

Salimos **para** México mañana.
We leave for Mexico tomorrow.

A DEADLINE

Lo necesito **para** el lunes.
I need it by Monday.

AN OPINION

Para mí, es fácil.
For me, it’s easy.

When to use por

WHY: BECAUSE OF, THANKS FOR

Gracias **por** todo.
Thanks for everything.

THROUGH OR ALONG

Caminamos **por** el parque.
We walked through the park.

IN EXCHANGE, A PRICE

Lo compré **por** diez dólares.
I bought it for ten dollars.

HOW YOU DO IT

Hablamos **por** teléfono.
We talked on the phone.

HOW OFTEN

Voy dos veces **por** semana.
I go twice a week.

Watch out: the meaning changes

Lo hice para ti.
I made it for you (a gift).

Lo hice por ti.
I did it because of you, on your behalf.

Trabajo para una aerolínea.
I work for an airline (my employer).

Trabajo por mi familia.
I work for my family’s sake.

Picture an arrow. **Para** flies to its target: a person, a purpose, a place, a deadline. **Por** passes through: a cause, a route, a trade, a way of doing it.

SOURCES

- RAE–ASALE, Nueva gramática básica de la lengua española (2011): the prepositions por and para.